

Homework Assignment 1: Slab-Geometry Boltzmann Equation

Tal Ramot

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1 Question 1 - Useful identity for the solution of the time-dependent slab-geometry Boltzmann equation

In this question we are asked to prove the following identity:

$$\psi(x, \mu, t; c) = ce^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \psi(cx, \mu, ct; 1) \quad (1)$$

We will do it in two parts. First, we will write down the equation that $\tilde{\psi} = \psi(cx, \mu, ct; 1)$ satisfies, and then we will use it in order to prove that the product $ce^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \tilde{\psi}$ satisfies the same equation as $\psi(x, \mu, t; c)$.

1.1 The equation for $\tilde{\psi}$

Notation: We will denote by $\Psi(X, \mu, T) \equiv \psi(X, \mu, T; 1)$ the $c = 1$ solution written in its own variables, and by Ψ_T and Ψ_X its partial derivatives with respect to them, so that $\tilde{\psi}(x, \mu, t) = \Psi(cx, \mu, ct)$ with $X = cx$ and $T = ct$. **This notation is used to avoid confusion when using the chain rule, as will be done immediately.** First, Ψ satisfies the $c = 1$ equation in the variables X and T :

$$\frac{1}{v} \Psi_T + \mu \Psi_X + \Sigma_t \Psi = \frac{\Sigma_t}{2} \int_{-1}^1 \Psi d\mu' \quad (2)$$

which after applying the chain rule, $\Psi_T = \frac{1}{c} \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial t}$ and $\Psi_X = \frac{1}{c} \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial x}$, and multiplying by c , becomes:

$$\frac{1}{v} \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial t} + \mu \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial x} + c \Sigma_t \tilde{\psi} = \frac{c \Sigma_t}{2} \int_{-1}^1 \tilde{\psi} d\mu' \quad (3)$$

So $\tilde{\psi}$ obeys the same equation as $\psi(x, \mu, t; c)$ except that it is removed at the rate $c \Sigma_t$ instead of Σ_t .

1.2 Proving the identity

In this part we are going to simply substitute the RHS of 1 into the LHS of the equation for $\psi(x, \mu, t; c)$ and show that it satisfies the same equation. After substitution and application of the chain rule we

get:

$$\text{LHS} = \frac{1}{v} \left[c(c-1)v\Sigma_t e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \tilde{\psi} + c e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial t} \right] + \mu c e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial x} + \Sigma_t c e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \tilde{\psi} \quad (4)$$

$$= c e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \left[\frac{1}{v} \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial t} + \mu \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial x} + \Sigma_t \tilde{\psi} + (c-1)\Sigma_t \tilde{\psi} \right] \quad (5)$$

$$= c e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \left[\frac{1}{v} \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial t} + \mu \frac{\partial \tilde{\psi}}{\partial x} + c\Sigma_t \tilde{\psi} \right] \quad (6)$$

$$= c e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \frac{c\Sigma_t}{2} \int_{-1}^1 \tilde{\psi} d\mu' = \frac{c\Sigma_t}{2} \int_{-1}^1 c e^{-(1-c)v\Sigma_t t} \tilde{\psi} d\mu' \quad (7)$$

where 3 was used in the last line, and this is exactly the RHS of the equation for $\psi(x, \mu, t; c)$.

2 Question 2 - Derivation of the time-dependent planar scalar flux for a plane source

The relation between a plane source and a point source as studied in class is given by:

$$\phi_{\text{pl}}(x) = 2\pi \int_{|x|}^{\infty} \phi_{\text{pt}}(r) r dr \quad (8)$$

The solution taken from J. C. J. Paasschens is the point-source scalar flux $\phi_{\text{pt}}(r, t)$ for $c = 1$, and therefore the planar-source scalar flux is given by the integration given above. [We abbreviate \$a = v\Sigma_t t\$.](#)

$$\phi_{\text{pl}}(x, t) = 2\pi \int_{|x|}^{\infty} \frac{e^{-v\Sigma_t t}}{4\pi r^2} \delta(r - vt) r dr + 2\pi \int_{|x|}^{\infty} \frac{(1 - r^2/v^2 t^2)^{1/8}}{(4\pi vt/(3\Sigma_t))^{3/2}} e^{-v\Sigma_t t} G\left(v\Sigma_t t \left[1 - \frac{r^2}{v^2 t^2}\right]^{3/4}\right) \Theta(vt - r) r dr \quad (9)$$

$$= \frac{e^{-v\Sigma_t t}}{2vt} \Theta(vt - |x|) + \Theta(vt - |x|) \frac{2\pi e^{-v\Sigma_t t}}{(4\pi vt/(3\Sigma_t))^{3/2}} \int_{|x|}^{vt} \left(1 - \frac{r^2}{v^2 t^2}\right)^{1/8} G\left(v\Sigma_t t \left[1 - \frac{r^2}{v^2 t^2}\right]^{3/4}\right) r dr \quad (10)$$

$$\stackrel{\xi=r/vt}{=} \frac{e^{-v\Sigma_t t}}{2vt} \Theta(vt - |x|) + \Theta(vt - |x|) \frac{2\pi e^{-v\Sigma_t t} (vt)^{1/2}}{(4\pi/(3\Sigma_t))^{3/2}} \int_{\frac{|x|}{vt}}^1 (1 - \xi^2)^{1/8} G\left(a [1 - \xi^2]^{3/4}\right) \xi d\xi \quad (11)$$

$$\stackrel{u=1-\xi^2}{w=vtu^{3/4}} \frac{e^{-v\Sigma_t t}}{2vt} \left[1 + \sqrt{\frac{3}{\pi}} \int_0^{w_0} \sqrt{w} G(w) dw \right] \Theta(vt - |x|) \quad (12)$$

with $w_0 = vt \left(1 - \frac{x^2}{(vt)^2}\right)^{3/4}$, the powers combining as $\frac{1}{6} + \frac{1}{3} = \frac{1}{2}$ and the Σ_t dependence cancelling in the last step (I used the assistance of AI in this algebraic derivation). Finally, with the interpolation formula of Paasschens, $G(w) = e^w \sqrt{1 + b/w}$ with $b = 2.026$, the integral has a closed form:

$$\int_0^{w_0} e^w \sqrt{w + b} dw = e^{w_0} \sqrt{w_0 + b} - \sqrt{b} - \frac{\sqrt{\pi}}{2} e^{-b} \left[\text{erfi}(\sqrt{w_0 + b}) - \text{erfi}(\sqrt{b}) \right] \quad (13)$$

which **closes the derivation of the planar-source scalar flux for $c = 1$** . Of course the relation proved in Q1 can be used to get the solution for $c \neq 1$ using a simple scaling and multiplication by an exponential factor of the solution for $c = 1$.